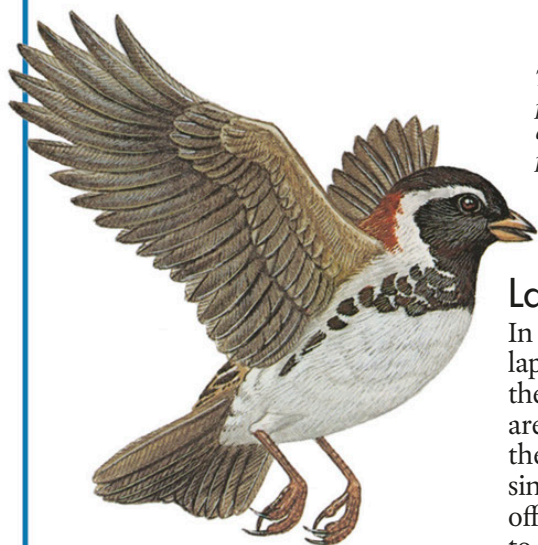


The Arctic



THE ARCTIC REGION lies right at the top of the planet. It is mostly made up of an ice-covered ocean, but it also includes the northern tips of North America, Europe, Asia, and Greenland. Arctic land that is not covered in ice has a low, flat tundra landscape, with many lichens, mosses, grasses, and ground-hugging bushes.

Not many birds can live in the Arctic all year because it is so cold, particularly in winter when it is dark all day from October until March. During the few light summer months, many birds migrate to the Arctic to nest and feed. At this time of year, microscopic plants and animals in the sea grow quickly with the light and warmth. They are eaten by fish, which in turn provide food for millions of gulls, auks, and terns. On the tundra lands, some of the ice melts, flowers make seeds, and insects hatch. Waders, ducks, geese, and smaller birds hurry to eat the seeds or insects, lay their eggs, and raise their young before flying south to escape the harsh Arctic winter.



Lapland longspur
(*Calcarius lapponicus*)
Length: 7 in (17 cm)

The male's summer breeding plumage helps him attract a female. He becomes much paler than this in winter.

Lapland longspur

In the summer months, the lapland longspur migrates to the Arctic tundra to nest. There are no trees in the tundra for the male to perch on while he sings to attract females or warn off rival males. Instead, he has to stand on rocks or fly up in the air to sing. The lapland longspur often nests in small groups for protection from predators.

Long-tailed duck

In the Arctic summer, the yodeling courtship call of male long-tailed ducks carries long distances across the open tundra landscape. Long-tailed ducks are very good at diving and can plunge as deep as 180 ft (55 m) to chase and catch fish. In areas of shallow water, they take shellfish and other small animals from the muddy bottom.

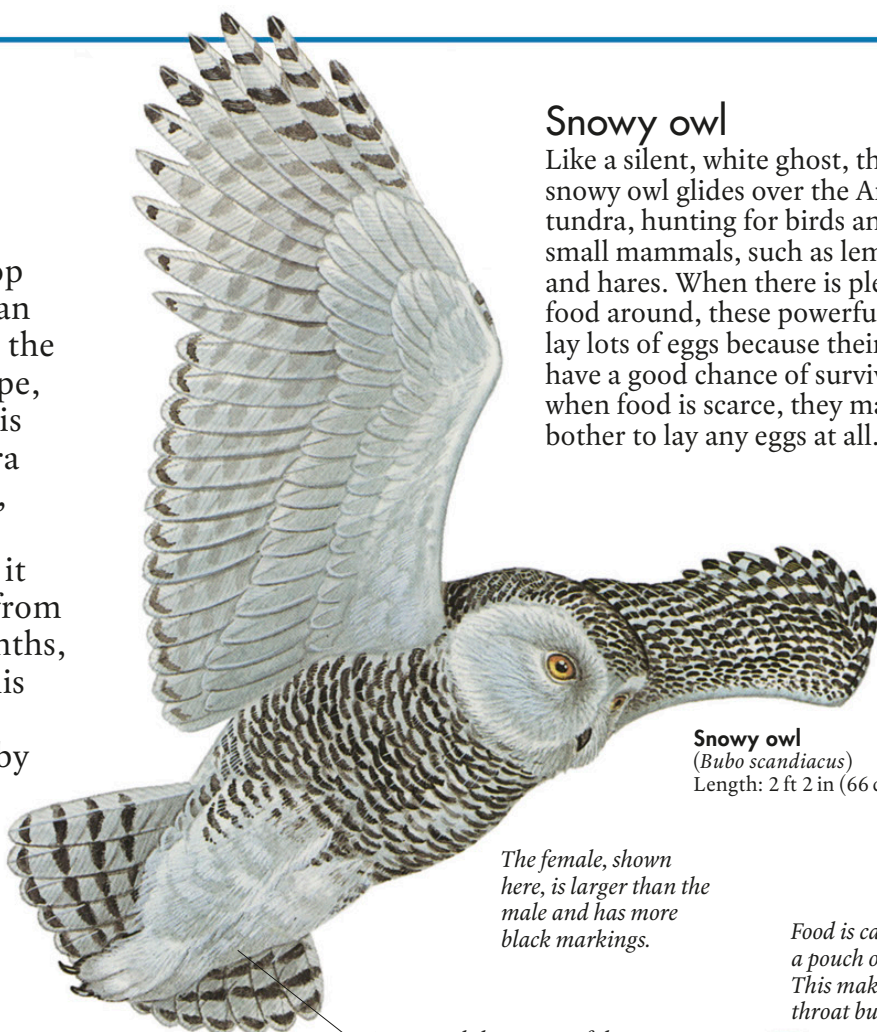
Long-tailed duck
(*Clangula hyemalis*)
Length: 2 ft (60 cm)



The female has dark cheek patches.

The male has long tail feathers.

Male and female ducks in summer plumage, which is mainly brown with white patches. In winter, it is the opposite—mainly white with brown patches.



Snowy owl

Like a silent, white ghost, the snowy owl glides over the Arctic tundra, hunting for birds and small mammals, such as lemmings and hares. When there is plenty of food around, these powerful owls lay lots of eggs because their chicks have a good chance of survival, but when food is scarce, they may not bother to lay any eggs at all.

Snowy owl
(*Bubo scandiacus*)
Length: 2 ft 2 in (66 cm)

The female, shown here, is larger than the male and has more black markings.

Snowy owls have powerful legs and talons for attacking and carrying off heavy prey.

Food is carried in a pouch or crop. This makes the throat bulge out.

Little auk

These tiny birds look like the penguins of the Antarctic because they live and feed in a similar way. Their bodies are streamlined for swimming underwater and they use their flipper-like wings to push them along. A thick layer of fat keeps them warm in the cold Arctic seas. Millions of little auks, or dovebies as they are sometimes called, raise their young on the Arctic coasts in summer. They move south in winter, but they do not usually go far beyond the Arctic Circle.



Little auk
(*Alle alle*)
Length: 8 in (20 cm)